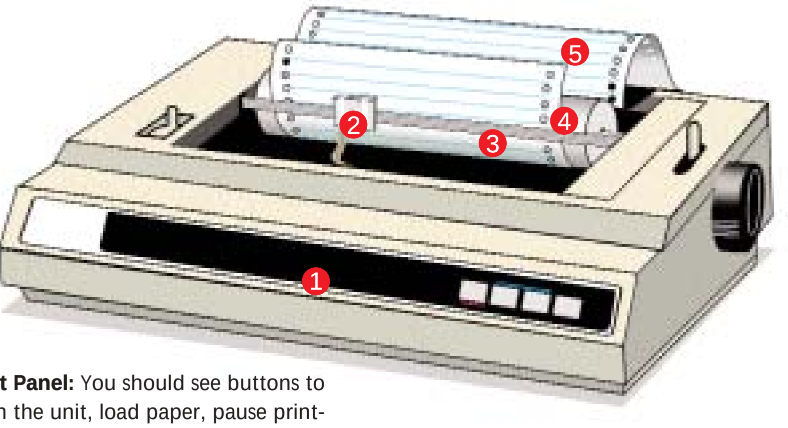
PRINTERS (DOT MATRIX)



❶ **Front Panel:** You should see buttons to power on the unit, load paper, pause printing, select a font, etc.
❷ **Head:** The printer head consists of either 9 or 24 pins that hit the paper through the ribbon to create the image on the paper. 24-pin printers provide better quality then 9-pin printers.
❸ **Ribbon:** The ribbon is a nylon strip impregnated with ink which gets transferred to the paper whenever the pins strike it. The replacement of a ribbon is simple as well as cheap.
❹ **Roller:** The roller has sensors attached to it which detect the paper. The roller pulls the paper into the printer.
❺ **Slots:** Slots on the paper provide traction.

Buying Tips

☑ **NUMBER OF PINS:** Here, pins refer to the metal pins on the printer head. Since every character or image is made up of dots, the more the number of pins, the better the print quality. There are two options to choose from—9 pins and 24 pins. Opt for a 24-pin print head as far as possible, since it'll provide better print quality.
☑ **BUFFER:** A large buffer allows for quicker printouts.
☑ **PAPER FEED METHOD:** Friction Feed as well as Tractor Feed should be supported. In Friction Feed, the printer pulls in a sheet from a stack of paper as and when needed. The Tractor Feed mechanism has spokes that fit into the perforations on either side of the paper, and the paper consists of a continuous sheet that can be torn at fixed lengths. Opt for printers that have Top, Bottom and Rear feeding.
☑ **AUTOSHARE (ALSO CALLED AUTOSWITCHING):** Some printers with both serial and parallel interfaces can be connected to 2 PCs simultaneously. The printer senses the PC that is sending data, and switches to the corresponding port. This feature, called AutoShare, does not come with all dot matrix printers.
☑ **LANGUAGE PRINTING CAPABILITIES:** Dot matrix printers are capable of printing in languages other than English. Look for a printer that has the facility to download different language fonts through a flash ROM.
☑ **PRINTING CARBON COPIES:** A lever to the side of the printer lets you decide the thickness of the paper. Combining this with a continuous sheet of type 1+1, 1+2, etc. enables you to print more than one copy simultaneously. Here, 1+1, 1+2, etc. indicate that one copy will be the original while there can be more than one carbon copy. Ready stationary to print carbon copies is available in the market.

Do Remember

- Make a rough calculation of the ribbon's replacement over the life of the entire unit before buying a dot matrix printer. Prints in draft mode are economical.
- In case you intend using colour ribbons, make sure you buy one that is of good quality. Though a little expensive, they do give you value for money in the long run.

Quick Find

Basic Use	YOU NEED	To print bills and invoices on A4 size paper
	LOOK FOR	An 80-column printer
Inter Use	YOU NEED	To print reports, worksheets, and balance sheets on A3 size paper
	LOOK FOR	A 136-column printer

Facts

- Dot matrix printers have a very running cost. They are therefore an ideal option for very large print jobs where quality is not so important.
- Change ribbons as soon as they begin to fade. The ink in the ribbons is used by the print head as a lubricant for the wires or pins. Dried-up ink causes undue wear and tear on the individual pins.

The Future

With the evolution of Inkjet and laser printing technologies, experts had predicted the death of the dot matrix printer a long time ago. However, though these printers have moved out of the home environment, they have settled into their own niche and are far from being extinct. The fact of the matter is that no other printing technology is more suitable for printing in bulk—especially in the area of billing. Though inkjets and the laserjets are much better when it comes to aspects such as print quality and speed, the low running costs and reliability of a dot matrix printer makes it a dependable choice for very large, average-quality print jobs. Indeed, they will command a portion of the market for some time to come.